

PC Mania

Also Remember...

■ When deciding on a configuration for your PC don't just go ahead and start picking the components. It makes sense to start with a list of what you want to use the PC for and the amount of money that you are willing to spend.

■ While most people seem to just want an Intel processor inside, you should have a look at AMD's Duron and Athlon procesors which deserve serious consideration.

■ Microsoft's Windows XP is due for launch in the near future and will require systems with higher hardware configurations than the current generation of operating systems. Make sure you keep this in mind if you are buying a PC today.

■ Most new motherboards come with sound integrated into them. However, if you are considering buying a quality set of speakers then it is worth spending the extra money on a good four-channel PCI sound card.

A desktop PC is an amalgamation of several components described in other sections of this guide. This makes deciding which PC to buy a considerably more complicated task. Whether you are interested in buying a system being offered by a prominent brand or want to pick each and every component and have it put together with your local assembler, you need to know what exactly to look for.

Anyone buying a PC today is pretty spoilt for choice. You have a wide range of pretty powerful systems available in the market today. And the cost isn't too steep either. With recent price reductions you can now get a high-performance Pentium 4 or Athlon-based PC for less than Rs 45,000.

SMART TIPS

Monitor: Refer to the guide to CRT monitors on page 96.

Keyboard and mouse: Refer to the keyboard guide on page 107 and the pointing devices guide on page 117.

Processor: Refer to the processor guide on page 118.

Motherboard: Refer to the motherboard guide on page 110.

Memory: Check for the type of RAM supported by your motherboard. PC133 SDRAM is the best choice for new PCs. However, Pentium 4 systems require either the more expensive RDRAM, or in some cases DDR SDRAM.



Storage: Refer to the hard disk drive guide on page 105 and external storage devices guide on page (XX)

Floppy and DVD/CD-ROM drives: Refer to the DVD/CD-ROM guide on page 100.

Sound: Refer to the speakers guide on page 121.

Cabinet: Refer to Agent 001's report on buying cabinets on page 153.

Operating system: Today, for most people the choice is between Windows Me/98 and Windows 2000 that costs considerably more.

	Budget PC	Midrange PC	Performance
You need	A low-cost PC for occasional gaming, small-time office usage, Internet surfing, and perhaps a few processor-intensive applications	A PC for running applications that are fairly graphics and processor intensive such as entertainment and gaming and are ready to shell out a little extra for the added performance	A PC with the best possible combination of performance and features and are willing to pay the premium this requires
Look for	A Celeron/Duron-class processor rated at 600 to 900 MHz with a standard 5400-rpm 20-GB hard disk and integrated sound and multimedia	A better motherboard (815 chipset instead of 810) with onboard TNT2 or Savage Pro graphics card. Storage would generally be a 20-40 GB hard disk	At least a Pentium 4 1.4 GHz and above or AMD Athlon 1.2 GHz with 256 MB of RAM, 7200-rpm 40-GB hard drive with a GeForce-class graphics card
Our pick	Nebula Qmax Triad	VisuaLan Lavish P4, VisuaLan Lavish PIII	Dell Dimension 8100, Amdell Monster PC1400
Price range	Up to Rs 35,000	Rs 35,000 to 50,000	Rs 50,000 and above



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